insider reveals, "We were aware that apart from voter weariness over sitting MLAs, there was also *karyakarta* [worker] fatigue, and we had to change that. So, instead of top-tier leaders, we chose mandal-level ones to introduce new blood, invigorate the cadres and groom them to be the next generation of leaders. Even though it was a risk, the prime minister insisted we do it because he said we can't wait for everything to fall into place. We should be the change we want to be."

But, in the aftermath of these moves, there were a few shocks—like senior leader and former CM Shettar switching over to the Congress when he was denied the party ticket from Hubli-Dharwad Central. It was the same story with Savadi, another senior hand and a former deputy chief minister, who was overlooked for the ticket to the Athani constituency in the BJP stronghold of Belagavi. Both are Lingayats, which meant their exit had the BJP scrambling to manage the optics given that the Lingayats have been their mainstay in Karnataka. Yediyurappa, the tallest Lingayat leader, had to be called in for damage control. "After Shettar went away," he said, "none of his followers who are elected members followed him. Not even a single person. Believe it or not, Shettar himself is going to lose."

But if the ticket distribution exercise was meant to usher in sweeping changes in Karnataka where the party has its own set of factional issues, that has not happened because several new candidates were still picked on the basis of their family connections. For instance, Yediyurappa's son B.Y. Vijayendra got the ticket to his Shikaripura seat. In Shettar's case, the BJP admits that its top leaders tried to convince him to stay by offering to nominate his wife, or any other family member, as the candidate for Hubli Dharwad Central in his place, but he refused. Another complaint was that many of the MLAs who had defected to the party from the Congress and the JD(S) were given tickets at the expense of loyalists, as a quid pro quo for enabling a BJP majority in the assembly. A senior BJP party member explained, "There is just so much surgery that the party organisation can handle and survive. We have replaced the intestine and the liver, next time we can do the heart." The BJP also didn't want to send a wrong message to those who had defected to the party not just in Karnataka but in other states as well that the party discards them at will.

To counter the effects of anti-incumbency, the BJP has replaced 20 sitting MLAs and brought in fresh faces in as many as 80 constituencies

THE CORRUPTION CONUNDRUM

Corruption remains the lead issue for the Congress in its face-off with the ruling BJP. For the past year and a half, the label of '40 per cent commission sarkar' has dogged the Bommai government. This allegation was made by a state contractors' association in a letter to the PMO alleging graft in the award of tenders. The BJP's problems didn't end there—a party worker died of suicide in April 2022, making the same allegation against a senior minister (who later got a clean chit). Soon after, a police recruitment scam came to light, leading to the arrest of a senior police officer. Topping all this, in March 2023, came the arrest, by the Lokayukta, of BJP MLA K. Madalu Virupakshappa in a corruption case. Bommai denies the '40 per cent' charge saying the contractors who raised the complaint have provided no evidence yet. He also said he has put a system in place to ensure tenders are transparent and corruption is curbed. Bommai goes on to accuse the previous Congress regime of being totally corrupt. To which Siddaramaiah retorts, "Did they raise any scam during our tenure? If they are doing it now, can you believe it? They were in power for four years. Why didn't they do an inquiry?"

The Congress is also milking the Nandini vs Amul issue and using it to invoke Kannadiga pride. The controversy began in December when Shah, also the Union minister for cooperation, inaugurated a mega dairy in Mandya district and spoke about how Amul and Nandini will work together towards establishing primary dairies in every village in Karnataka and that the Karnataka Milk Federation "will be provided with technical support, cooperative sector support and overall functioning support" from Amul. This led to a furore about a possible 'Gujarati' takeover. Mandya, the heartland of Vokkaliga politics, is in the Old Mysuru region where the BJP has been trying to secure a foothold. Thus, on April 5, when Amul tweeted about its entry into Bengaluru to supply milk and curd, it kicked up a storm.

Siddaramaiah accused the Modi government of trying to impose a "One Nation, One Milk" policy and said it would put the state's 2.6 million milk farmers at a disadvantage and that they should be protected. The BJP rushed to control the damage, with Karnataka cooperation minister S.T. Somashekar saying no merger was on the cards and that all 15 milk unions under the Karnataka Milk Federation in the state were profitable. The minister also pointed out that Amul was only selling its milk via e-commerce at Rs 57 a litre while Nandini was cheaper at Rs 39 a litre in outlets. Besides, Nandini products were being sold in 12 states, including Gujarat, he said. Various Amul products, too, have been available in Karnataka for years. However, in the middle of an election, the milk row has become a matter of Kannada pride.

On its part, the BJP is hoping the issue will recede closer to election day. Meanwhile, it is persisting with its other major election plank: reminding voters of the massive welfare schemes that both the state and central government have launched. The party is using the claim that these have impacted almost every section of society to underline the benefits of a "double-engine sarkar". The schemes being touted are flag-